

USER INTERVIEW TRANSCRIPTS

1. Elena, Veterinarian

I have been a veterinarian in this neighborhood for eleven years, and I probably talk to someone about adoption at least once a week. Sometimes it is a family whose cat just died. Sometimes it is a first-time pet owner who has no idea where to start. People assume I know which rescues are responsible, so even a casual comment from me can send someone toward one organization and away from another.

What matters to me is not whether a rescue has the cutest social media page. I want to know how they handle medical information and whether they are honest when information is incomplete. A rescue cat may arrive with no history at all. That is normal. What concerns me is when an adopter is told a cat is perfectly healthy and then discovers significant dental disease or a chronic condition two weeks later. I do not expect certainty. I expect transparency.

I also notice how well a rescue prepares adopters for ordinary problems. A cat hiding for several days, refusing a new food, scratching furniture, or developing stress-related behavior does not automatically mean the adoption failed. But if people are not prepared, they panic. I have had clients come into the clinic saying they are thinking of returning a cat after four days because it has not become affectionate yet. Good preparation can prevent that.

When I trust a rescue, I recommend it without hesitation. I keep their cards at the clinic, mention them to clients, and sometimes refer people who find strays or need help rehoming a cat. When I do not trust one, I am careful not to attach my professional reputation to it. One poorly handled adoption can stay in my mind for years.

I am not the person adopting the cat, but I can influence whether someone feels confident enough to adopt at all. If a rescue gives clear medical records, realistic behavior information, and good post-adoption resources, I become one of their strongest advocates. If they exaggerate, hide problems, or pressure people emotionally, I stop recommending them.

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2. Jonah, Remote Project Manager

I am thirty-six, single, and I work from home most of the week. I moved into a larger apartment last year, and for the first time I feel like I have the space, money, and routine to adopt a cat properly. I have been thinking about it seriously for about three months. This is not a someday idea anymore. I would like to adopt within the next few weeks if I find the right match.

I do not have a specific look in mind. I actually think I would prefer an adult cat because I work long hours sometimes and I do not want the chaos of a kitten. What I care about most is personality. I want a cat that enjoys company but can also be independent when I am in meetings. I would rather have an honest description saying a cat is shy, vocal, or not very cuddly than a vague profile that calls every cat 'sweet.'

I have already priced food, litter, annual vet care, pet insurance, and a carrier. The money does not scare me, although I still want to understand what medical issues are known before I commit. My bigger fear is choosing badly. I know adoption is emotional, and I worry that I will see a cat, feel sorry for it, and ignore information that tells me we are not actually a good fit.

The application process seems reasonable to me as long as someone explains why the questions matter. I am happy to provide proof that pets are allowed in my building and talk about my schedule. What would frustrate me is waiting a week for every reply or getting rejected without understanding why. I am ready to make a decision, so I need the rescue to be organized enough to help me move forward.

My goal is pretty simple: I want to bring home a cat that can realistically live with me for the rest of its life. I am not looking for entertainment for a few months or a cute photo. I am looking for a companion, and I want the rescue to help me make a responsible match rather than just get an animal out the door.

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3. Nadia, Condo Resident and Cat Owner

I already have a cat, so I am not looking to adopt another one. One is enough for my apartment and my budget. But I follow the rescue because they post useful information about cat behavior, low-cost vaccination clinics, microchipping days, and what to do if you find a lost cat. That kind of information is actually why I keep paying attention to them.

Last year my cat slipped into the hallway when a delivery person came in and disappeared for almost a day. I completely panicked. A volunteer from the rescue explained how to search the building and suggested putting familiar-smelling items near my door. We found him that night. After that, I started seeing the rescue as more than a place where people go to adopt.

I have attended one of their nail-trimming demonstrations and a short workshop about introducing cats to visitors. I like practical events where I learn something I can use immediately. I have also donated twenty or thirty dollars a few times when they posted about an emergency surgery, but I would not describe myself as a regular donor. I help when something catches my attention and I can afford it.

What turns me off is when every message feels like a crisis. If every post says 'urgent,' 'desperate,' or 'last chance,' eventually I stop reading because I feel guilty and overwhelmed. I want to support the rescue, but I do not want every interaction with them to make me feel as if I am personally responsible for solving animal homelessness.

I am probably not their main customer. I am not going home with a cat. But the rescue still has value for me as a local source of advice, services, and community information. If they make existing cat owners feel included, I am more likely to attend events, share posts, donate occasionally, and tell other people about them.

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4. Trevor, Sales Representative

I want a kitten, and I do not see why getting one needs to be complicated. I have a good job, I own my condo, and I am willing to pay the adoption fee. To me, that should be enough. I went on one rescue website and the application was ridiculous. They wanted to know how many hours I work, where the cat would sleep, what I would do if I moved, and whether I would return the animal if it scratched furniture. I stopped halfway through.

I am specifically looking for a young kitten because I want to raise it my way. I do not want an older cat with habits I did not choose or some unknown history. I also want one that looks a certain way. If I am going to have an animal for years, I should be allowed to care about appearance. Rescue people act like that makes you shallow, but they are not the ones living with the cat.

I travel fairly often, but cats are supposed to be independent. I have friends who could stop by and refill food if I am gone. I am not paying for a pet sitter every time I leave town. I also have a leather sofa that cost a lot of money. If scratching became a problem, I would look at whatever option solves it, including declawing if a veterinarian would do it. I know shelters hate that, but I do not think they should get to control what happens after I pay for the cat.

The other thing I do not understand is all the talk about 'matching.' I am not applying for a child. I want a pet. If I choose one and it turns out to be aggressive, destructive, or too much work, I would expect to be able to bring it back and choose another. That seems normal to me. Stores let you return things that do not work out.

If a rescue starts lecturing me about commitment, enrichment, scratching posts, or how I need to change my lifestyle, I am gone. There are breeders and people online selling kittens with far less hassle. I am not interested in being educated by a shelter. I want a healthy, attractive kitten quickly, with as few restrictions as possible.

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5. Amira, Parent of Two

My husband and I have two children, eight and twelve, and we have been discussing adopting a cat for almost a year. We deliberately waited until after our summer travel because we did not want to bring an animal home and then disappear two weeks later. The kids know this is not a birthday surprise. We have talked about feeding, litter, vet visits, and the fact that the adults are ultimately responsible.

We are ready now. We have permission from our landlord, we have set aside money for the adoption fee and first vet visit, and we have a quiet room where a new cat could stay while it adjusts. What we do not know is which cat would actually thrive with us. My youngest is energetic and affectionate. My older child is quiet and would probably want a cat beside them while they read. I do not want to choose based on which face the kids fall in love with first.

I am especially interested in how the rescue evaluates behavior around children. A profile that says 'good with kids' is not enough. Does the cat enjoy being touched? Does it startle easily? Does it walk away when overwhelmed or does it swat? I am not expecting a guarantee, but I want enough detail to make a thoughtful decision.

I also want the kids to meet the cat before we commit. Partly because I want to see the interaction, and partly because I want them to understand that the cat gets a choice too. If a staff member tells us that the cat we like is not a good fit, I am prepared to listen. I would rather disappoint the kids for a day than create a stressful home for an animal for years.

For us, success means adopting once and doing it well. We are not browsing for fun. We are actively trying to bring a cat into our family soon, and we need the rescue to help us translate our good intentions into the right match. Clear information, patient guidance, and a chance to meet appropriate cats would make me feel confident enough to move forward.

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6. Ben, Pet Supply Store Manager

I manage an independent pet supply store about ten minutes from the rescue. Customers ask us about adoption all the time, especially people buying supplies for their first pet. We keep flyers from a few local organizations near the register, and we have hosted adoption events in the store parking lot. I have learned that people often decide which rescue to contact based on one recommendation from someone they already trust.

I am selective about who we partner with. If an organization cancels events at the last minute, gives us incorrect information, or sends volunteers who are rude to customers, it reflects on my business too. On the other hand, when a rescue is organized and treats people well, I am happy to promote them. I can mention them dozens of times in a month without making it feel like advertising.

I also hear the questions people are embarrassed to ask the rescue directly. How much does a cat really cost every month? Will the shelter judge me if I work full-time? What if I rent? What if I have never had a pet? Sometimes people assume rescue organizations only want experienced animal people. A friendly recommendation from us can make the process feel less intimidating.

What I do not like is when rescues use partnerships only to ask for free products. We are a small business. I can donate food sometimes, offer a discount for adopters, or host a collection bin, but I cannot supply unlimited litter because a social media post says they are desperate. A good relationship has to work both ways.

If I trust the rescue, I can send them adopters, donors, foster volunteers, and customers who found stray cats. I can also make their organization visible to people who would never follow an animal rescue account. But I need consistent communication and professional behavior before I put their name beside mine.

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7. Celeste, College Student

I am twenty and live in a residence where animals are not allowed, so adopting is completely unrealistic for me right now. Even if pets were allowed, I move every eight months and I work part-time. I know I am not in a stable enough stage of life to take responsibility for a cat. I miss animals, though. My family has two cats back home, and going from that to a tiny residence room felt strange.

I started volunteering at the rescue because I wanted somewhere to be around cats without pretending I was ready to own one. I go most Sunday mornings. I clean, refill water, do laundry, and sometimes sit with shy cats. I actually like the quiet jobs. School is competitive and everything feels like it is being graded. At the rescue, nobody cares about my GPA. There is just work that needs to be done.

I do not see myself adopting from them this year or next year. Maybe after graduation, but that is far enough away that I do not plan around it. What I get from the rescue now is different: routine, a break from campus, a chance to meet people outside my program, and the feeling that a few hours of my week are useful to something other than school.

The hardest part is that volunteer communication can make me feel unreliable. Sometimes they send a message saying they urgently need extra help on a weekday afternoon. I cannot skip class, but I still feel guilty saying no. I wish there were more ways to contribute that fit around student schedules instead of emergencies always being treated as the most valuable kind of help.

I am not coming to the shelter because I need a cat. I am coming because the experience itself matters to me. If they make volunteering structured, welcoming, and flexible, I will keep showing up and I will probably bring friends. If every interaction becomes pressure to donate more money or take on more responsibility, I will eventually stop going.

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8. Colin, Property Owner

I own a small rental building near the rescue, and I will be clear: I do not like cats in my units. I have had tenants leave behind scratched doors, damaged blinds, litter odors, and flea problems. Maybe responsible owners are different, but I am the one paying for repairs when things go wrong. So when applicants ask whether they can adopt a cat after moving in, my answer is usually no unless their lease already allows it.

I also think the rescue encourages people to make emotional decisions without considering the people around them. Someone sees a sad cat online, decides they have to save it, and suddenly the landlord, roommate, or neighbor is expected to accommodate the choice. Then if there is a problem, everyone acts as if you are cruel for objecting because it is an animal.

The rescue has held weekend events nearby, and I find them annoying. More cars, people blocking driveways, carriers on the sidewalk, volunteers putting posters on every bulletin board. I understand they think they are doing something good, but not everyone wants the neighborhood organized around cats. There are plenty of human problems that need money and attention too.

I would never donate, foster, volunteer, or attend an adoption event. I do not follow animal rescue accounts and I have no interest in educational workshops. If anything, I would prefer the rescue to make it harder for renters to adopt unless they can prove in writing that their landlord allows pets. That would save everyone trouble later.

People can call me anti-cat if they want. I do not hate individual animals; I just do not think their needs should automatically come before property rules, neighbors, or costs. The rescue's whole message is about making room in your life for an animal. My priority is minimizing risk and inconvenience. Those values are not going to line up, and I am not looking for them to.